Political Science 3100
American Legislative Process
MWF 9:00am, Holman Hall 138
Fall 2026

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Office Hours:
Monday 1:30pm – 3:00pm
Wednesday 10:30am – 12:00pm

OBJECTIVES

This course is an introduction to the politics, policies, and procedures of the U.S. Congress. After taking this course, you should be able to:

- understand the organizational structure and procedural rules that shape policy;
- evaluate the incentives and behavior of members of Congress;
- think critically and empirically about political interactions in and with Congress; and
- analyze political arguments, applying the evidence and findings to new situations.

In pursuing these goals, we will tackle a variety of questions including, who runs for and wins seats in Congress, and how might this bias representation? How is Congress organized to contend with an increasingly large workload? What role does an individual member play in the legislative process and what responsibilities have been delegated to party leaders? How does political control shape policy outcomes? How has Congress changed over time? Is Congress fulfilling its constitutional duty, and how might it be modernized to optimize its performance?

It is my hope that you leave the semester knowing more about American government and politics, able to think critically about political interactions in contemporary American politics. Furthermore, I hope that this course inspires greater engagement in public affairs by connecting political science to live questions in American politics.

REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

Two Exams (50%)

Exams will be taken in class. The first exam will be taken in class on Monday, October 12th. The second exam will be taken during the final-exam period, which is Wednesday, December 9th at 8:00am. The closed-book exams will consist of both short-answer and longer essay questions. The short-answer section of the final will not be comprehensive, but the essays will include questions that ask you to use ideas from throughout the course. Before each exam, I will make available a list of possible essay questions. No notes or outlines will be permitted at either exam. The midterm exam will be worth 20% and the final exam will be worth 30% of your overall grade.

Writing Assignments (40%)

You will submit three writing assignments for this class. The first assignment will be in a traditional paper format and will consist of an examination of a House member and her district. You will collect data about that representative's career, electoral situation, representational style, and

Washington activity, and your paper will use this data to answer the question: how does this member represent her constituency and why? This paper will be worth 20% of your overall grade.

The second and third papers will each be slightly shorter and non-traditional. Your second assignment will be to write a two-page memorandum to the legislator you selected for your first assignment. In this memo, you will assume the role of a congressional staffer and provide your "boss" a recommendation for how she should vote on a particular bill. The third assignment will be to write a letter to a constituent in response to their inquiry about why your boss took the stance she did on that bill. Each of these two shorter assignments will be worth 10% of your overall grade.

More information regarding these assignments will be provided as the due dates approach. Each prompt will be discussed in class and posted on Blackboard. Papers will be submitted via the Blackboard and are due by 11:55pm on October 2nd, October 23rd, and November 16th. A 5% reduction will be applied to your assignment's grade for each day it is late. Unless explicitly authorized for a particular assignment, generative AI may not be used for producing written work.

In-Class Participation via Poll Everywhere (10%)
As this grade indicates, a successful student will not only be present at every class meeting, but come prepared to engage with the material. I cannot make you come to class, pay attention, or participate in discussion. What you get out of this class (and your entire Ole Miss education) is up to you. To gauge participation and preparedness, we will utilize an online quiz platform called Poll Everywhere. These questions are to be answered in class. You will receive a zero on this portion (10%!) of your final grade if you are found to be answering questions from a distant location. (Trust me, I have methods to determine if you are in the classroom or not.)

Poll Everywhere Instructions

This course will utilize Poll Everywhere through your smart device. I prefer you use a smart phone for ease, but a laptop or tablet will work, too. I have registered all students as participants in my Poll Everywhere course with your go.olemiss.edu email address. If you have not logged in to Poll Everywhere before, your password is your eight-digit student ID number. You must log in with this account for your responses to be counted. We will walk through how to use this system and have a few practice days to work out technological difficulties before polls begin counting toward your grade.

Poll Everywhere Grading

We will utilize two types of Poll Everywhere questions: 1) reading-assessment polls and 2) thought/activity polls. Reading-assessment polls will be conducted at the outset of most classes. These are intended to assess the extent to which students have read and understand the course material. Reading-assessment polls will be graded as follows: 100% if you answered the question correctly; 50% if you answered the question incorrectly; and 0% if you did not answer the question/a response was not recorded. Thought/activity polls will typically be conducted during the middle of class. They will be graded as follows: 100% if you answered the question and 0% if you did not answer the question/a response was not recorded. Polls will be graded using this criteria beginning September 9th. This should give everyone ample time to navigate the setup and software.

Each day, one of the reading-assessment questions will be denoted as an extra-credit opportunity. If at least 80% of the class answers this question correctly, one person in the class will have the opportunity to take a basketball shot for extra credit. If the student makes the shot, the entire class will earn one bonus point on the next exam.

There are no opportunities to make up missed Poll Everywhere questions – this includes missed questions due to both absence and/or incorrect responses. I will drop the lowest 10% of everyone's polls to accommodate occasional absence, technology problems, athletic travel, lateness, etc. We will have many opportunities for participation that missing one or two days in the semester will not affect your Poll Everywhere grade. If you have many absences due to extended illness, we will address this at the end of the semester with the necessary documentation. Because I drop 10% of your Poll Everywhere grades, there is no need to email me for absences or to request a make up.

Grading Scale
The criteria for how your grades will be assigned and how they should be interpreted are listed below.

Grade Letter	Points/Percentage	Description
A	93–100	Extremely good
A-	90–92	Very, very good
B+	87–89	Very good
B	83–86	Good
B-	80–82	High-average
C+	77–79	Average to low-average
C	73–76	Mildly subpar
C-	70–72	Severely subpar
D	60–69	Markedly poor
F	0–59	Self-explanatory

COURSE POLICIES, EXPECTATIONS, AND RESOURCES

Getting Help
I will post most of our course information to our Blackboard site and utilize Blackboard's messages feature. Please be sure to enable email notifications for course announcements. If you have outstanding questions after consulting our syllabus and the Blackboard site, please feel free to email me, stop by my office hours, or set up a meeting with me. When emailing me, please include "POLS 3100" in the subject line and I will do my best to get back to you within two business days.

Please do not feel intimidated to come to my office hours or set up a meeting with me, if my office hours do not work with your schedule. I am here to be a resource for you, and office hours are a great time to meet in a low-stakes environment. You are more than welcome to come alone or with a friend, talk about the course, get feedback on paper ideas and outlines, ask questions before an exam, or just chat about the latest political happenings or college football.

Technology Policy
You will need to bring a device with internet accessibility (i.e., a laptop, tablet, or smartphone) to class to answer our Poll Everywhere questions. Other than using these devices to participate in this manner, technology is prohibited in our classroom. As technology is not permitted in this

course, it should go without saying that the recording of any lectures or class discussions without prior permission is expressly prohibited.

Expectations

I expect all students to behave professionally and respectfully in this class. As one should expect of a course on American politics, we will often discuss issues of public contention and controversy. In order to facilitate a classroom environment that supports a respectful and critical inquiry through the exchange of multiple perspectives, we will embrace disagreement in the spirit of an open, deliberative democracy. Accepting the fact that constructive disagreement sharpens critical thinking and deepens understanding, it is not only encouraged, but expected. To encourage this robust discussion, please adhere to the following guidelines:

- Debate and discuss ideas, philosophies, and arguments, not individuals or groups
- Make attempts to listen to and engage with viewpoints that differ from your own
- Enter this classroom with humility, giving yourself and others permission to experiment freely with ideas

Additionally, given that this is a course about American politics and government, you should be a regular, informed consumer of news and current events. Below are a handful of reputable sources to find a variety of news. I encourage you to enable notifications from these sources to stay up-to date on current events.

- *Washington Post* http://www.washingtonpost.com/politics/
- *New York Times* http://www.nytimes.com/topic/organization/us-congress
- *Wall Street Journal* http://www.wsj.com/news/politics
- *Politico* http://www.politico.com/congress
- *The Hill* http://thehill.com
- *Roll Call* http://rollcall.com

University Policies and Resources

- Academic Honesty Policy
- Attendance Verification Policy
- Student Accommodations Policy and Student Disability Services Resources
- Mental Health Resources

COURSE SCHEDULE AND READINGS

All listed readings are required, unless noted otherwise, and should be completed prior to the corresponding class for which they are listed. Optional readings provide additional depth or context, but are not required. Readings marked "skim" should be read with attention paid to central arguments, rather than minor details. Readings posted on Blackboard are marked **B**. Several readings are hyperlinked and available via the blue link.

Part I: The Design of a Representative Institution

M 8/24 — Course Introduction
- Review the syllabus

W 8/26 — The Dual Nature of Congress
- Green, Amelia Hoover. "How to Read Political Science: A Guide in Four Steps." **B**
- Mayhew, David R. 1974. *Congress: The Electoral Connection*, Chapter 1 (pp. 11–77). **B**

  I highly encourage you to read the rest of Mayhew's book when you get a chance. This is one of the most widely cited books on the U.S. Congress, and its influence can be seen in nearly all work on the U.S. Congress.

F 8/28 — The Design of Congress
- *Constitution of the United States.* **B**
- Federalist 56, 57, and 62

M 8/31 — Theories of Representation
- Paine, Thomas. 1776. "On the Origin and Design of Government in General." *Read through the seventh paragraph.*
- Burke, Edmund. 1774. "Speech to the Electors of Bristol."
- Glassman, Matt."Why Congress Doesn't Always Do the Right Thing." *The New York Times*, February 7, 2018. **B**
- Optional: NYT Editorial Board. "America Needs a Bigger House." *The New York Times*, November 8, 2018. **B**

W 9/2 — Who is Represented? *(And Regression Digression!)*
- Carnes, Nicholas. "Why are so few US politicians from the working class?" *The Guardian*, October 4, 2018.
- Minta, Michael and Valeria Sinclair-Chapman. 2012. "Diversity in Political Institutions and Congressional Responsiveness to Minority Interests." *Political Research Quarterly.* **B**

F 9/4 — No Class: American Political Science Association Annual Meeting

M 9/7 — No Class: Labor Day

Part II: Running for Office

W 9/9 — Electoral Rules: Apportionment and Redistricting

- "Apportionment and Redistricting Process for the U.S. House of Representatives." *Congressional Research Service*, pp. 1–20.
- Optional: Allen, Danielle. "Just how big should the House be? Let's do the math." *The Washington Post*, March 28, 2023.
- Bring a laptop or tablet to class for an in-class activity on gerrymandering

F 9/11 — The Incumbency Advantage

- Drutman, Lee. 2021. "What We Know about Congressional Primaries and Congressional Primary Reform." *New America*, pp. 7–39. **B**
- Optional: Jacobson, Gary C. 2015. "It's Nothing Personal: The Decline of the Incumbency Advantage in US House Elections." *Journal of Politics.* **B**

M 9/14 — Candidate Emergence and Ambition

- Thomsen, Danielle M. and Aaron S. King. 2020. "Women's Representation and the Gendered Pipeline to Power." *American Political Science Review.* **B**

W 9/16 — Campaigning

- Grimmer, Justin. 2013. "Appropriators not Position Takers: The Distorting Effects of Electoral Incentives on Congressional Representation." *American Journal of Political Science.* **B**
- Optional: Hunt, Charles and Casey Burgat. "The who, what, when, where, and why of congressional campaign spending." *LegBranch.org*, September 25, 2018.

F 9/18 — Who Wins?

- Porter, Rachel and Sarah A. Treul. 2023. "Evaluating (In)Experience in Congressional Elections." *American Journal of Political Science.* **B**
- Skim: Fiorina, Morris P. 2016. "The (Re)Nationalization of Congressional Elections." *A Hoover Institution essay on contemporary American Politics.* **B**

Part III: Staying in Office

M 9/21 — Role of a Member

- "Life in Congress: The Member Perspective." *Congressional Management Foundation*, 2013. **B**

W 9/23 — Home Style

- Fenno, Richard F. 1977. "U.S. House Members in Their Constituencies: An Exploration." *American Political Science Review.* **B**

F 9/25 | Hill Style
- Burgat, Casey. "Five legislative styles of members of Congress." *LegBranch.org*, November 20, 2017. **B**
- Optional: Bernhard, William, Daniel Sewell, and Tracy Sulkin. 2017. "A Clustering Approach to Legislative Styles." *Presented at the 2013 Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association.* **B**

M 9/28 | No Class: University of Iowa Conference on Congressional Elections

W 9/30 | Responsiveness and Accountability
- Ansolabehere, Stephen and Philip Edward Jones. 2010. "Constituents' Responses to Congressional Roll-Call Voting." *American Journal of Political Science.* **B**

Part IV: Congressional Organization and Leadership

F 10/2 | Political Parties in Congress
- Lee, Frances. 2016. "Legislative Parties in an Era of Alternating Majorities." In *Governing in a Polarized Age.* **B**
- **Paper 1 due by 11:55pm**

M 10/5 | Leadership and the Centralization of Power
- Curry, James M. 2015. *Legislating in the Dark: Information and Power in the House of Representatives*, Introduction (pp. 1–21). **B**
- Drutman, Lee. "House leadership has been writing bills behind closed doors for years." *Vox*, March 3, 2017. **B**

W 10/7 | Committees and Staff
- Ommundsen, Emily Cottle. 2023. "The Institution's Knowledge: Congressional Staff Experience and Committee Productivity." *Legislative Studies Quarterly.* **B**
- Optional: Curry, James M. 2020. "Change and Continuity for Committees in Congress." In *New Directions in Congressional Politics.* **B**
- Optional: Furnas, Alexander C. et al. 2020. "The Congressional Capacity Survey: Who Staff Are, How They Got There, What They Do, and Where They May Go." In *Congress Overwhelmed.* **B**

F 10/9 | Catch Up & Review
- Begin reviewing and bring questions to class

Midterm Exam on Monday, October 12th

Exam will be administered in person during our regularly scheduled class time.

Part V: The Lawmaking Process

W 10/14	The Textbook Process • Davidson, Roger H., Walter J. Oleszek, Frances E. Lee, Eric Schickler, and James M. Curry. 2024. *Congress and Its Members*, 19th ed., Chapter 8 (pp. 203–242). **B**
F 10/16	The Contemporary House • Sinclair, Barbara. 2017. *Unorthodox Lawmaking: New Legislative Processes in the U.S. Congress*, 5th ed., Chapter 2 (pp. 10–46). **B**
M 10/19	The Contemporary Senate • Koger, Gregory. 2020. "The U.S. Senate: A Chamber at a Crossroads" in *New Directions in Congressional Politics*, 2nd ed. Jamie L. Carson and Michael S. Lynch, eds. **B** • Wallner, James. "Why Senators Prefer Cloture." *Legislative Procedure: Explaining how Congress actually works*, July 13, 2026.
W 10/21	Budget and Appropriations Process • Reynolds, Molly. 2025. "Carrying the Conflict: The Politics of the Budget and Appropriations Process in the Contemporary Congress" in *Congress Reconsidered*, 13th ed. Lawrence C. Dodd, Bruce I. Oppenheimer, Ruth Bloch Rubin, and C. Lawrence Evans, eds. **B**
F 10/23	Reconciling Differences • Oleszek, Walter J. 2008. "Whither the Role of Conference Committees: An Analysis." *Congressional Research Service.* **B** • **Paper 2 due by 11:55pm**
M 10/26	Pivotal Politics • Woon, Jonathan. 2009. "Change We Can Believe In? Using Political Science to Predict Policy Change in the Obama Presidency." *PS: Political Science and Politics.* **B** • Optional: Krehbiel, Keith. 1998. *Pivotal Politics: A Theory of U.S. Lawmaking*, Chapter 2. **B**
W 10/28	Lawmaking Case Study: Health-Care Reform • Watch: "Obama's Deal." *PBS: Frontline*, April 13, 2010. (Link)

Part VI: Policymaking and Inter-Branch Relations

F 10/30 — Congress and the Executive Branch

- Riccardi, Nicholas and Linley Sanders. "Americans think a president's power should be checked, AP-NORC poll finds – unless their side wins." *The Associated Press*, April 5, 2024. **B**
- Portman, Rob and Chuck Grassley. "Biden's student loan debt transfer is an abuse of executive power." *The Washington Examiner*, September 8, 2022. **B**
- Kaysen, Ronda. "How a Housing Bill Trump Spurned Became Law." *The New York Times*, July 25, 2026.

M 11/2 — Congress and the Courts

- Bailey, Michael A., Forrest Maltzman, and Charles R. Shipan. 2025. "Congress and the Judiciary in a Partisan and Polarized Era" in *Congress Reconsidered*, 13th ed. Lawrence C. Dodd, Bruce I. Oppenheimer, Ruth Bloch Rubin, and C. Lawrence Evans, eds. **B**

W 11/4 — Election Debrief

- Vote on Tuesday and watch the election returns!

F 11/6 — Congress and External Influences

- Davidson, Roger H., Walter J. Oleszek, Frances E. Lee, Eric Schickler, and James M. Curry. 2024. *Congress and Its Members*, 19th ed., Chapter 13 (pp. 361–384). **B**

M 11/9 — Policy Productivity and Party (In)Capacity

- Curry, James M. and Frances E. Lee. 2019. "Non-Party Government: Bipartisan Lawmaking and Party Power in Congress." *Perspectives on Politics*. **B**

W 11/11 — Bipartisan Cooperation

- Harbridge-Yong, Laurel, Craig Volden, and Alan E. Wiseman. 2023. "The Bipartisan Path to Effective Lawmaking." *Journal of Politics*. **B**
- Optional: Curry, James M. and Jason M. Roberts. 2023. "Inter-Personal Relationships and Legislative Collaboration in Congress." *Legislative Studies Quarterly*. **B**

F 11/13 — Earmarks and Domestic Policy

- Kaslovsky, Jaclyn and Andrew R. Stone. 2024. "Geographic representation and requests for federal funds in the U.S. Senate." *Legislative Studies Quarterly*. **B**

M 11/16 — Foreign Policy

- Davidson, Roger H., Walter J. Oleszek, Frances E. Lee, Eric Schickler, and James M. Curry. 2024. *Congress and Its Members*, 19th ed., Chapter 15 (pp. 413–436). **B**
- **Paper 3 due by 11:55pm**

Part VII: Reforming Congress

W 11/18	120th Congress: What's Next? • TBD
F 11/20	Modernization • "Recommendations to Foster Collaboration and Civility in Congress, to Modernize the Congressional Support Agencies, and to Encourage Evidence-Based Policymaking." *U.S. House of Representatives Select Committee on the Modernization of Congress* ("ModCom"). **B**
M 11/23	No Class: Thanksgiving Break
W 11/25	No Class: Thanksgiving Break
F 11/27	No Class: Thanksgiving Break
M 11/30	Congressional Capacity • Ommundsen, Emily Cottle. 2025. "Getting What You Pay For: Resource Allocations and Legislative Success." *Legislative Studies Quarterly.* **B**
W 12/2	Is Congress Broken? • Hibbing, John R. and Christopher W. Larimer. 2008. "The American Public's View of Congress." *The Forum.* **B**
F 12/4	Catch Up and Review • Begin reviewing and bring questions to class

Final Exam on Wednesday, December 9th
Exam will be administered in person at 8:00am.